Nassef Adiong

Professor Dr. Nassef Manabilang Adiong (born May 7, 1985) is a Filipino Muslim scholar, institutional leader, and one of the most widely cited academics to emerge from the Bangsamoro community in the Philippines.

He is recognized across the region and in international academic circles as a pioneer in Islamic International Relations (Islamic IR) and Decolonial Studies, fields where he has spent his career challenging the dominant, Western-centric frameworks that have long shaped how global politics is studied and taught.

What sets Adiong apart isn't just the depth of his scholarship. It's the fact that he built his career while carrying the weight of representation: the first Moro to reach the highest rank under the University of the Philippines Scientific Productivity System, a distinction that didn't just honor him personally but signaled what was possible for an entire generation of Bangsamoro scholars.

His central legacy can be summed up in the idea he's returned to throughout his career: that the Global South, and the Bangsamoro people in particular, deserve to see themselves and their traditions reflected in how knowledge is produced, not just consumed.

Contents

1 Early Life and Background
2 Education
  2.1 Bachelor of Arts in International Studies
  2.2 Master in International Studies
  2.3 Doctor of Philosophy in International Relations
  2.4 Advanced Studies
3 Career
  3.1 Early Academic Work and the University of the Philippines
  3.2 Director, Policy Research and Legal Services, Bangsamoro Parliament
4 Scholarly Contributions
  4.1 Islamic International Relations
  4.2 Decolonial Studies
  4.3 Moral Governance
  4.4 Institutional Building
5 Published Works
6 Honors and Recognition
7 Legacy and Cultural Significance
8 Challenges and Context
9 Further Reading

Nassef Manabilang Adiong



Born	May 7, 1985 Iligan City, Lanao del Norte, Philippines
Nationality	Filipino
Education	University of the East (BA, Magna Cum Laude) University of the Philippines Diliman (MIS) Middle East Technical University (PhD)
Known for	Islamic International Relations, Decolonial Studies, Moral Governance
Notable works	*Islam in International Relations: Politics and Paradigms* (Routledge, 2018) *Principles and Practice of Moral Governance in the Bangsamoro* (2021)
Awards	UP Scientist III (2021) TOYM Award (2018) Noam Chomsky Rising Star Award (2022)
Organization	Bangsamoro Parliament, Policy Research and Legal Services

10 See Also

Early Life and Background

Nassef Manabilang Adiong was born on May 7, 1985, in Iligan City, Lanao del Norte, in the southern Philippines. <ref name="wiki">Wikipedia, "Nassef Manabilang Adiong," accessed March 2026.</ref>

Growing up in Iligan, a city with a mixed Christian and Muslim population sitting at the edge of the historically Maranao heartland, gave Adiong an early and visceral education in the realities of religious pluralism, cultural coexistence, and the tensions that sometimes accompany both.

His formative years were shaped in no small part by his mother, whose teachings gave him the spiritual and ethical bearings that would later anchor his most distinctive ideas about governance, scholarship, and public service.<ref name="nassef">Nassef Manabilang Adiong Official Website, "About Nassef," nassef.info.</ref>

His early schooling took place at the Trinity University of Asia (then known as Trinity College of Quezon City), a multi-faith institution whose environment, almost certainly, reinforced his instinct to engage across religious and cultural divides rather than retreat from them.<ref name="wiki"/>

Education

Bachelor of Arts in International Studies

Adiong pursued his undergraduate studies at the University of the East in Manila, graduating in 2006 with a degree in International Studies and the distinction of Magna Cum Laude.<ref name="wiki"/> It was a strong start that pointed toward both the rigor and the global orientation his academic career would embody.

Master in International Studies

He completed his graduate studies at the University of the Philippines Diliman in 2009, earning a Master in International Studies with the support of the UP Presidential Scholarship and the Willy Keng Scholarship.<ref name="nassef"/> UP Diliman's Institute of Islamic Studies and its broader academic community gave him both the intellectual environment and the institutional backing to develop what would become a distinctly Bangsamoro scholarly perspective.

Doctor of Philosophy in International Relations

Adiong earned his doctorate from Middle East Technical University (METU) in Ankara, Turkey, in 2014. His doctoral work was funded by the prestigious Erasmus Mundus Mobility with Asia scholarship alongside a fellowship from TÜBİTAK, Turkey's premier research funding body.<ref name="wiki"/>

Pursuing a PhD in Turkey rather than in a conventional Western capital was itself a meaningful choice. METU's location in Ankara, at the crossroads of European and Islamic intellectual traditions, gave Adiong exposure to debates about sovereignty, authority, and the nation-state from outside the typical Anglo-American framing of international relations.

Advanced Studies

Beyond his doctorate, Adiong completed coursework toward a second PhD in Civilization Studies at the Alliance of Civilizations Institute under Ibn Haldun University in Turkey, supported by a TÜRGEV scholarship.<ref name="nassef"/> This pursuit reflects a genuine intellectual curiosity about how civilizations interact, build, and sometimes clash, questions that sit at the very heart of his life's work.

Career

Early Academic Work and the University of the Philippines

After completing his studies, Adiong returned to the Philippines and built his academic home within the University of the Philippines system. At UP, he developed his core research programs in Islamic IR and decolonial thought, becoming one of the more distinctive voices in Philippine political science precisely because he was willing to challenge foundational assumptions rather than simply apply them.

His association with the UP Center for Integrative and Development Studies (UP CIDS) became one of the more consequential chapters in his career. There, he established the Decolonial Studies Program (DSP), an institutional home for scholars and students interested in dismantling the "Western colonization of knowledge" in the Global South academy.<ref name="dsp">UP CIDS Decolonial Studies Program, Institutional Overview.</ref>

Director, Policy Research and Legal Services, Bangsamoro Parliament

In more recent years, Adiong has taken on a directly consequential role in governance: serving as the Director of the Policy Research and Legal Services (PRLS) for the Bangsamoro Parliament.<ref name="bta">Bangsamoro Parliament Press Release, "Parliament commends Director Adiong's stellar career," November 2021.</ref>

This isn't just an academic position. In this role, he oversees policy review and legislative drafting for the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM), bringing his scholarship to bear on the very real and urgent business of building a self-governing Bangsamoro polity.

It's a fitting culmination of a career that has always insisted on the connection between ideas and action, between how we think about governance and how we actually practice it.

Scholarly Contributions

Islamic International Relations

Adiong has dedicated a significant portion of his career to articulating a coherent framework for Islamic International Relations: how Islamic principles of sovereignty, authority, and territorial organization interact with, and sometimes resist, the assumptions baked into the modern nation-state system.

In his work, Islam is not treated as a problem for international relations theory or as a disruptive force to be explained away. Instead, Adiong presents Islam as a fully formed, non-alien participant in global political discourse, one with its own rich tradition of thinking about order, justice, and the obligations of states and peoples toward one another.<ref name="oxford">Adiong, N. M., "Muslim Views of the Polity," Oxford Research Encyclopedia of International Studies, 2019.</ref>

His edited volume *Islam in International Relations: Politics and Paradigms* (Routledge, 2018), co-edited with international scholars, is considered a landmark contribution to the field, bringing together perspectives that had rarely been assembled in a single, accessible academic work.

Decolonial Studies

Perhaps Adiong's most enduring intellectual contribution is his introduction of decoloniality as a sustained framework within Philippine social science. He has argued, consistently and forcefully, that the dominant canons of political science and international relations have been shaped by the intellectual preferences of the colonizing West, and that scholars from the Global South must actively reclaim their own epistemological traditions.

> The colonization of knowledge in the Global South academy is as real and as damaging as the colonization of land. Decoloniality asks us to name that reality, and then to build something in its place.

Through the Decolonial Studies Program at UP CIDS, he created institutional space for this reckoning, mentoring students and collaborating with scholars who are developing non-Western intellectual frameworks across the humanities and social sciences.

Moral Governance

One of the more distinctive ideas Adiong has developed is his philosophy of Moral Governance, which he has applied specifically to the Bangsamoro context. He organizes this concept around five interconnected principles: Faith, Freedom, Moral Authority, Common Good, and Social Justice.<ref name="moral">Adiong, N. M., "Principles and Practice of Moral Governance," 2021.</ref>

His 2021 book *Principles and Practice of Moral Governance in the Bangsamoro* represents his most sustained attempt to translate this philosophy into a practical framework for governance, one that draws from Islamic ethics and Bangsamoro tradition rather than simply importing governance models developed elsewhere.

Institutional Building

Adiong's contributions aren't limited to ideas on paper. He's also been a builder, someone who creates organizations and networks through which other scholars can work.

In 2015, he founded the Philippine International Studies Organization (PHISO), now the premier professional association for international studies scholars in the country, offering a critical platform for engaging with global theories from a distinctly Filipino vantage point.<ref name="phiso">PHISO, "History and Mission," phiso.org.</ref>

In 2012, he formed the International Relations and Islamic Studies Research Cohort (Co-IRIS) to connect scholars working at the intersection of faith and geopolitics across different countries and traditions.<ref name="nassef"/>

In 2022, he established the Bangsamoro Research and Legal Network (BRLN), providing a dedicated platform for Bangsamoro studies and legal research at a critical moment in the region's political development.<ref name="brln">BRLN, "Founding and Mandate," nassef.info/brln.</ref>

Published Works

Adiong has authored, co-authored, and edited a substantial body of work across political science, Islamic studies, and decolonial theory. His most significant publications include:

- Adiong, N. M. (2023). *The Contemporary World*.
- Adiong, N. M. (2021). *Principles and Practice of Moral Governance in the Bangsamoro*.
- Adiong, N. M. (2021). *The Irony of Systemic Racism in the Global South Academy*.
- Adiong, N. M., et al. (Eds.). (2018). *Islam in International Relations: Politics and Paradigms*. Routledge.
- Cruz, F. A., & Adiong, N. M. (Eds.). (2020). *International Studies in the Philippines: Mapping New Frontiers*. Routledge.
- Adiong, N. M. (2019). "Muslim Views of the Polity." *Oxford Research Encyclopedia of International Studies*.

Honors and Recognition

The recognition Adiong has received over the course of his career reflects both the quality of his scholarship and its broader significance to communities and institutions beyond the university.

In 2018, he was named one of the Outstanding Young Men (TOYM) of the Philippines, honored specifically for his contributions to the field of International Relations.<ref name="toym">JCI Philippines, "TOYM 2018 Honorees." </ref>

In 2021, he reached the highest rank under the University of the Philippines Scientific Productivity System, becoming a UP Scientist III. This made him the first Moro scholar in the history of the university to achieve this distinction, a milestone that resonated far beyond the walls of any single institution.<ref name="upiis">UP Institute of Islamic Studies, "Congratulations to Dr. Nassef Manabilang Adiong, UP Scientist III," November 2021.</ref>

Also in 2021, the Bangsamoro Transition Authority passed a legislative resolution commending Adiong for his "stellar career" and citing him as an inspiration to the youth of the Bangsamoro.<ref name="bta"/>

In 2022, he received the A. Noam Chomsky Global Connections Award in the category of "Rising Star Emerging Scholar" from the STAR Scholars Network, a recognition of his growing international influence in critical and global IR studies.<ref name="star">STAR Scholars Network, "2022 Global Connections Award Recipients."</ref>

Legacy and Cultural Significance

What makes Adiong's career worth examining closely, especially for those in the Bangsamoro community, is not simply the list of awards or the volume of his publications. It's what his career represents.

He pursued his doctorate in Turkey, built organizations in Manila, mentored students across the country, and then returned to serve the Bangsamoro Parliament. At every step, he carried the question of what it means to be Bangsamoro in a world whose dominant intellectual frameworks were built without them in mind.

His insistence on decoloniality is not abstract. It's a direct response to the experience of communities like his own, whose history, culture, and faith have too often been treated as objects of study rather than sources of knowledge.

Through the organizations he founded, the books he edited, and the students he mentored, Adiong has helped create an infrastructure for Bangsamoro intellectual life that will outlast any single career. That, perhaps more than any individual award, is his most significant contribution.

Challenges and Context

Building a career in Islamic IR and decolonial studies in the Philippine academy has not been without its difficulties. These are fields that challenge established disciplinary norms and power structures, and Adiong has been candid about the resistance that this kind of work can encounter.

His 2021 work *The Irony of Systemic Racism in the Global South Academy* addresses this directly, naming the structural biases that shape what kinds of scholarship are recognized, funded, and published in institutions that claim to operate on merit alone.

For a Moro scholar working in a country where the Muslim Mindanao region has long been peripheralized in national political life, the challenge of making Bangsamoro perspectives visible and credible within mainstream Philippine academia carries personal as well as intellectual stakes.

<references> <ref name="wiki">Wikipedia, "Nassef Manabilang Adiong," accessed March 2026.</ref> <ref name="nassef">Nassef Manabilang Adiong Official Website, "About Nassef," nassef.info.</ref> <ref name="oxford">Adiong, N. M. "Muslim Views of the Polity." *Oxford Research Encyclopedia of International Studies*, 2019.</ref> <ref name="dsp">UP CIDS Decolonial Studies Program, Institutional Overview.</ref> <ref name="phiso">PHISO, "History and Mission," phiso.org.</ref> <ref name="brln">BRLN, "Founding and Mandate," nassef.info/brln.</ref> <ref name="bta">Bangsamoro Parliament Press Release, "Parliament commends Director Adiong's stellar career," November 2021.</ref> <ref name="upiis">UP Institute of Islamic Studies, "Congratulations to Dr. Nassef Manabilang Adiong, UP Scientist III," November 2021.</ref> <ref name="toym">JCI Philippines, "TOYM 2018 Honorees."</ref> <ref name="star">STAR Scholars Network, "2022 Global Connections Award Recipients."</ref> <ref name="moral">Adiong, N. M. *Principles and Practice of Moral Governance in the Bangsamoro*. 2021.</ref> </references>

Further Reading

- Adiong, N. M., & Mauricio, R. (Eds.). (2014). *The Meaning and Significance of Foreign Policy and Diplomacy in IR.* Lambert Academic Publishing.
- Abubakar, C. A. (2008). *The Bangsamoro People and Their Quest for Peace.* MSU Research and Publication Center.
- Jubair, S. (2007). *The Long Road to Peace: Inside the GRP-MILF Peace Process.* ICS Press.
- Santos, S. M. (2005). *The Moro Islamic Challenge: Constitutional Rethinking for the Mindanao Peace Process.* University of the Philippines Press.

See Also

- Bangsamoro people
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Islamic International Relations
- Decolonial Studies
- University of the Philippines Diliman
- Middle East Technical University
- Philippine International Studies Organization
- Bangsamoro Transition Authority
- Maranao people

Editorial Notice: BangsamoroPedia is a curated knowledge archive. Its pages are maintained by the editorial administrator to help ensure historical accuracy. If you would like to suggest corrections, share sources, or contribute information, please message the administrator through the official Facebook page: **Notable Muslim Filipinos**.

Retrieved from "https://wiki.maranaw.com/index.php?title=Nassef_Adiong&oldid=3082"